EW 18 ARTICLES

100. ARTICLES

101. The DEFINITE ARTICLE (*le, la, l', les*) MUST BE USED in the following cases:

a) in universal statements, to denote a category or type

Lions are dangerous : *Les lions sont dangereux*
I like tea : *J'aime le thé*

b) with titles

General de Gaulle : *le Général de Gaulle* Captain Scott : *le capitaine Scott*

c) **with proper names qualified by an adjective** poor Mary : *la pauvre Marie*

d) **parts of the body** You must distinguish between:

A Actions which one does to one's own body

i) simple movement of a part of one's body, when nothing else is involved

He opened his mouth : *Il a ouvert la bouche*
I raised my arm : *J'ai levé le bras*

ii) action done by oneself to a part of one's own body requires that the verb become reflexive

She wiped her mouth : *Elle s'est essuyé_ la bouche*
They rubbed their eyes : *Ils se sont frotté_ les yeux*

B Actions done to another person's body

iii) action done to another person requires an indirect object pronoun to show possessor

(me, te, lui, etc)

He seized her arm : *Il lui a saisi le bras*
The cat jumped onto my lap : *Le chat m'a sauté sur les genoux*

BUT the possessive adjective (mon, ma mes etc) is used

i) when the part of the body stands as the subject

His feet were hurting him	:	*Ses pieds lui faisaient mal*
His face was quite red	:	*Son visage était tout rouge*

ii) when the part of the body is qualified by an adjective

I raised my hairy arm	:	*J'ai levé mon bras poilu*

e) "From" with countries

If the country is masculine use *du / des*	*Il est revenu du Japon / du Canada / des Etats-Unis*
BUT if the country is feminine use *de*	*Il est revenu de Suisse / d'Angleterre / de Belgique* (no article)

f) in translations of *with* in descriptive phrases

i) where it is a question of a PERMANENT FEATURE or AN ARTICLE OF DRESS use *à* + definite article (*au, à la, à l', aux*)

The woman with the red hat	*La femme au chapeau rouge*
The boy with blond hair	*Le garçon aux cheveux blonds*

ii) where it is a question of a TEMPORARY STATE the definite article stands alone (NO *avec*; NO *à*)

He came in with his hands behind his back	*Il est entré les mains derrière le dos.*

102. The DEFINITE ARTICLE is NOT USED in the following cases.

(In each case note carefully the exception)

a) **with verbs and adjectives that ALWAYS REQUIRE `de' before a following noun**

He did without wine	*Il s'est passé **de** vin*	covered in snow	*couvert **de** neige*
I need money	*j'ai besoin **d**'argent*	littered with books	*encombré **de** livres*

BUT if English has **`the'**, use one of **du, de la, de l', des**

The table was littered with the books he had left there	*La table était encombrée des livres qu'il y avait laissés.*
He did without the wine we had bought him	*Il s'est passé du vin que nous lui avions acheté*
I need the money I lent you	*J'ai besoin de l'argent que je t'ai prêté*

b) **with languages when used after *en* or with *parler***

We speak German	*Nous parlons allemand*
He wrote in Chinese	*Il a écrit en chinois*

BUT if *parler* is qualified by an adverb or adverbial phrase, or if the language is used with any verb other than *parler*, you must use a definite article

We are learning Spanish	*Nous apprenons l'espagnol*
I am studying Greek	*J'étudie le grec*
He speaks Italian fluently	*Il parle couramment l'italien*

c) **expressions of quantity are followed by `de' WITHOUT ARTICLE**

He drank four cups of tea / a lot of wine	*Il a bu quatre tasses de thé / beaucoup de vin*

BUT where English has `of the' use one of *du, de la, de l', des*

He drank four cups of the tea I had bought	*Il a bu quatre tasses du thé que j'avais acheté*
They drank a lot of the wine Paul had given us	*Ils ont bu beaucoup du vin que Paul nous avait donné*

d) **The following expressions of quantity are always followed by one of *du, de la, de l', des***

(some) more	**encore du/de la/des**	many	**bien des + plural verb**
most	**la plupart des + plural noun + plural verb**		

Would you like some more wine?	*Vous voulez encore du vin?*
Most people never go there	*La plupart des gens n'y vont jamais*

e) **with days of the week the definite article is not used**

Monday is the first day of the week	*Lundi est le premier jour de la semaine*
We played cards on Thursday (evening)	*Nous avons joué aux cartes jeudi (soir)*

BUT to translate "on" followed by a day of the week in the plural use *le*

We play cards on Thursdays	*Nous jouons aux cartes le jeudi*
I used to see him on Tuesday mornings	*Je le voyais le mardi matin*

f) **to translate "the more . . . the more" or "the less . . . the less"** do not use the definite article

The more I see him the less I like him	*Plus je le vois, moins je l'aime*
The more you read the wiser you are	*Plus on lit plus on est sage*

g) **no definite article is included with adjectival phrases**

i) indicating season / month

On a winter's day	*par un jour d'hiver*
One autumn evening	*par un soir d'automne*

ii) indicating type

A French lesson	*une leçon de français*

103. The INDEFINITE ARTICLE (*un*, *une*, *des*) is used as in English, but it is omitted in the following cases:

NOTE THAT THESE EXPLANATIONS IN THIS SECTION REFER ONLY TO THE INDEFINITE ARTICLE; IF THE ENGLISH HAD CONTAINED "THE" A DEFINITE ARTICLE WOULD BE USED.

a) **with occupations, nationalities and religions** omit the indefinite article after *être* and *devenir*

His father became a Catholic	*Son père est devenu catholique*
His brother is a doctor	*Son frère est médecin*
My teacher is a Frenchman	*Mon professeur est français*

BUT if the occupation or religion is qualified by an adjective the article must be included

His father became a good Catholic	*Son père est devenu un bon catholique*
His brother is a famous doctor	*Son frère est un médecin connu*

b) **Without any / a . . . & Without . . . or . . .** do not use an indefinite article

He arrived without a coat	*Il est arrivé sans manteau*
He left for Germany without luggage or money	*Il est parti pour l'Allemagne sans bagages ni argent*

c) **With/Without + abstract noun** **Avec / Sans** without indefinite article

They waited impatiently	*Ils ont attendu avec impatience*
They spoke without conviction	*Ils ont parlé sans conviction*

BUT, after **avec** & **sans**, if the abstract noun is qualified by an adjective, the indefinite article must be used

He showed great courage	*Il a fait preuve d'un grand courage*

d) **As a . . .** **Comme** without an indefinite article

As a student he is very gifted	*Comme étudiant il est très doué*
He works as a hairdresser	*Il travaille comme coiffeur*

g) **When a noun is in apposition** the INDEFINITE article is omitted

Manchester, a large industrial town	*Manchester, grande ville industrielle*
Louis Lumière, a chemist from Lyon	*Louis Lumière, chimiste de Lyon*

104. *des* will always shorten to *de* when it comes immediately before a plural adjective, unless *des* means "of the"

des hommes	BUT	**de beaux hommes**
j'en ai un autre	BUT	**j'en ai d'autres**
des filles	BUT	**de jolies filles**

BUT *beaucoup des jolies filles* because the meaning is "a lot of the pretty girls"

105. *du*, *de la*, *de l'*, *des* will always shorten to *de* after a negative if it expresses absence or lack

J'ai bu de la bière	BUT	*je n'ai pas bu de bière*
J'ai un stylo	BUT	*je n'ai pas de stylo*

NOTE
- *ne . . . que* is not a true negative — *je n'ai bu que de la bière*
- if the sentence using a negative does not express absence or lack, do not use *de*
  - This is not a pipe — *Ceci n'est pas une pipe* (Magritte)
  - They were not Germans — *Ce n'étaient pas des Allemands*